

How to Use The American Supplement Investigation

A reader's guide to Product Lookup and the rest of the site — searching a real supplement label, weighing the evidence behind it, and finding your way through the books, the Top 25 ranking, and the Evidence Library.

FOLLOW THE MONEY · FOLLOW THE SCIENCE · FOLLOW THE EVIDENCE

What This Guide Covers

The American Supplement Investigation is a free, independent website built around one live tool and a growing library of sourced, evidence-based guides. This short guide walks through both — how to search a real product and see the science behind it, and how to find your way through everything else the site offers.

No sponsorships fund this site, and nothing here replaces a conversation with your own doctor or pharmacist. Product Lookup and the research guides are built to help you ask better questions of both.

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Using Product Lookup

Product Lookup searches live against the NIH's own Dietary Supplement Label Database (DSLD) — over 200,000 real product labels — then helps you compare what it finds against the clinical evidence. Find it at supplements.brokenpromiseshealthcare.org/product-lookup, or the "Product Lookup" link in the top menu on any page.

1 Search by product name

Type a real product's name into the search box. Including the brand narrows things considerably — "Nature Made Vitamin D3" finds what you want much faster than just "Vitamin D." Results start appearing as you type; press Enter or wait a moment if nothing shows yet.

2 Select the matching product

Click "View label" on the correct brand and product from the results list. This pulls the complete label record — every declared ingredient and its exact dose, straight from the NIH's data, along with the label's suggested use, cautions, and allergen statements.

3 Click "Investigate the Evidence"

This is where Product Lookup goes beyond the label. It builds a research prompt containing this exact product's ingredients and doses, combined with the same evidence-evaluation standard used throughout this site's books and guides.

TIP

A product not turning up? Try the brand name alone, or drop a word like "Complex" or "Advanced" — NIH's label records use the exact wording printed on the bottle, which does not always match how a product is marketed online.

The screenshot shows the 'LIVE LOOKUP · NIH DATABASE' interface. At the top is a navigation bar with links: Home, Books, Research, Top 25, FAQ, Search, Product Lookup, What Should Change, About, and Contact. Below the navigation bar is a header with the text 'Look Up an Actual Product Label'. The main content area contains a search box with 'Vitamin D3' entered and a 'Search' button. Below the search box, two product results are displayed in a list. The first result is '100% Natural Vitamin D3' by 'Whole Body Research', with a 'View label' link. The second result is 'Absorbable Calcium 1200 mg Plus Vitamin D3 25 mcg', also with a 'View label' link.

Product Lookup: type a name, and results appear as you type.

Running & Reading the Evidence Check

4 Choose how you want to run it

Pick "Analyze with Claude," "Analyze with ChatGPT," or "Analyze with Perplexity" for a one-click analysis using your own account — or "Copy Full Research Prompt" to paste the same prompt into any AI tool you prefer, including one not listed.

5 Read the analysis, and check its sources

A good response leads with an overall verdict, then walks through each ingredient's evidence, how the product's dose compares to what was actually studied, and its safety profile. Treat every citation as a starting point for your own verification, not a final word.

"Investigate the Evidence": Your Options

Every option runs the identical methodology — only the destination changes, and none of them route through this site or cost anything beyond your own AI usage.

- **Analyze with Claude / ChatGPT / Perplexity** — opens a fresh conversation with the research prompt already loaded, using your own account. This site does not pay for, log, or see your analysis.
- **Copy Full Research Prompt** — copies the complete methodology and product data to your clipboard, to paste into Gemini or any other AI assistant. This keeps you from being locked into one provider.

What the Methodology Checks

Every prompt asks the AI to evaluate *this exact product and dose* — not the ingredient in the abstract. It prioritizes systematic reviews and randomized trials over anecdote; compares the product's actual dose to doses used in real clinical trials; flags known adverse effects, interactions, and contraindications; separates evidence for correcting a genuine deficiency from evidence for people who aren't deficient; and rates the strength of evidence for each major use (Strong / Moderate / Limited / No Benefit / Harm), with sources and publication dates.

INVESTIGATE THE EVIDENCE

Compares this exact formulation and dose with published clinical evidence — trial size, dose match, safety, and interactions — using an AI research assistant of your choice and your own account. This site pays nothing for your analysis, and you should verify important conclusions using the cited sources.

Analyze with ClaudeAnalyze with ChatGPTAnalyze with Perplexity

Copy Full Research Prompt

Perplexity runs automatically. ChatGPT opens with your prompt ready — press Enter to run it. Claude opens a blank chat — paste with Ctrl+V / Cmd+V, then press Enter.

The "Investigate the Evidence" panel, at the bottom of every product label.

What the Label Can — and Can't — Tell You

Product Lookup is not a database this site built or maintains. Every search runs live against the NIH Office of Dietary Supplements' Dietary Supplement Label Database (DSLD), a free, public, government-run record of what manufacturers have submitted. Keeping it that way is deliberate: the NIH stays the source of truth for what's on the label, and the site's own job is connecting that label to the actual evidence.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

Label data is manufacturer-reported and voluntary. The NIH itself notes that submitted labels "might be incomplete and/or inaccurate." A product's presence in the database is not an endorsement by NIH, FDA, or HHS — it is simply a record of what a label says.

The AI is a research assistant, not an authority. Treat its analysis as a well-structured starting point, not a verdict to accept uncritically. Verify anything important — especially safety or interaction concerns — against the cited primary sources and against a pharmacist or physician who knows your specific health situation.

This tool doesn't replace medical advice. It's built to help you ask better questions of your doctor or pharmacist, not to substitute for that conversation.

Quick Tips

- Product Lookup shows you the label. It does *not* carry this site's own evidence ratings — for that, pair it with the Top 25 guide (page 6) for the most commonly searched ingredients.
- The "Investigate the Evidence" prompt works with whatever ingredients are on the label — multi-ingredient blends get evaluated ingredient by ingredient, not just as a whole.
- Bookmark a product's label page if you want to return to it — results are pulled live each time, so re-running a search always reflects the current NIH record.

Data source: National Institutes of Health, Office of Dietary Supplements — Dietary Supplement Label Database (dslid.od.nih.gov). Public domain, CC0 1.0.

Research Guides & The Trilogy

The Top 25 Supplements Guide

[/top-25-supplements](#)

MARKET VS. EVIDENCE

America's 25 best-selling supplements, ranked by actual sales prominence and color-coded by evidence tier — Strong, Strong-Only-If-Deficient, Moderate, or Weak. Start at the "ranked by sales, at a glance" list near the top and click any entry to jump straight to its full write-up: efficacy, safety, and a one-line bottom-line verdict. The second tier is worth reading closely — it covers the supplements (Vitamin D, B12, Calcium, Iron) that genuinely work, but only for people who are actually deficient.

Strong Evidence A narrow, specific claim backed by rigorous, replicated trials.		Strong — Only If Deficient Real benefit, but only for people with an actual, diagnosed deficiency.	
Moderate Evidence A real effect exists, but it's smaller or narrower than what's marketed.		Weak Evidence Trial evidence doesn't support the primary reason people buy it.	
1	● Multivitamin/Multimineral		Very High
2	● Vitamin D		Very High
3	● Omega-3 / Fish Oil		Very High
4	● Vitamin C		Very High
5	● Protein Powder (Whey/Plant)		High
6	● Probiotics		High

The four evidence tiers, and the ranked list — click any entry to jump to its write-up.

The Books

[/#books](#)

THREE FREE VOLUMES, READ ONLINE

The trilogy behind the whole site, free to read in full online — no purchase or account needed. Each book's page has an "About the Book" overview and a "Read the Full Book" link that opens the complete text with a clickable table of contents.

Book One • What the Label Doesn't Tell You — evidence, anecdote, and how to tell a mechanism from a result.

Book Two • The Hollow Aisle — the regulatory gap, documented risk, and the business of belief. Closes with the free, printable *"What Are You Taking?"* medication-and-supplement worksheet — bring it to your next appointment.

Book Three • Prove It — real chronic-disease claims and documented case files, closing with the "What Should Change" policy appendix (page 8).

Evidence Library & FAQ

Evidence Library

[/annotated-bibliography](#)

EVERY SOURCED CLAIM, IN ONE PLACE

The full annotated bibliography behind every book and guide on the site — peer-reviewed studies, government reports, federal law, and court records, each verified against its primary source and linked with "Read the source." Type in the "Search sources" box to filter live as you type (no need to press Enter), or click a topic — Evidence & Claims, Regulation, Risk & Interactions, The Business, Physician Training, Chronic Disease Evidence, or International Comparison — to narrow the list.

Every entry below was independently verified against the primary source — not just checked for a working link, but read to confirm it actually says what it's cited for. Where our own research surfaced a mismatch between a claim and its source, we corrected the claim on the page in question rather than publish a citation that doesn't hold up; see [How We Source Claims](#). This bibliography currently covers the sourced claims already published across the site and will grow as new investigations are added.

Search sources

Search by title, author, topic, or keyword...

Filters the topics below as you type — no 'Enter' needed.

[All](#)
[Evidence & Claims](#)
[Regulation](#)
[Risk & Interactions](#)
[The Business](#)

[Physician Training](#)
[Chronic Disease Evidence](#)
[International Comparison](#)

Filter live as you type, or click a topic to narrow the bibliography.

Frequently Asked Questions

[/faq](#)

QUICK, SOURCED ANSWERS

Short, direct answers to the questions people actually ask — grouped into Safety & Interactions, Evidence & Efficacy, Regulation & Trust, Practical Dosing, and Is It Worth It. Each answer links to the fuller chapter or guide behind it, so the FAQ works well either as a fast reference or as a starting point before reading further.

HOW THESE TWO FIT TOGETHER

Start with the FAQ for a quick, plain-language answer. When you want to see the actual trial, report, or law behind that answer, follow its link into the Evidence Library and read the source directly.

Search Everything, the Policy Appendix & About

Site-Wide Search

[/search](#)

90+ INDEXED ENTRIES, GROWING

Search across all three books, every research guide, the FAQ, and the full bibliography at once — try a supplement name ("melatonin," "iron") or a topic ("interactions," "FDA"). Use the filter tabs — Top 25, FAQ, Guides, Bibliography, Books — to narrow results to one part of the site.

What Should Change

[/appendix-what-should-change](#)

BOOK THREE'S CLOSING APPENDIX

The site's own policy recommendation: a tiered evidence framework modeled on Canada's and Australia's working supplement regulatory systems — not full drug-style approval, and not the status quo. Read it on its own, or as the close of Book Three.

About & Contact

[/#about](#) · [/#contact](#)

WHO'S BEHIND IT, AND HOW TO REACH THEM

Background on Robert Coleman, MS Pharm. (forty years in medicine, sixteen as Director of Clinical Pharmacy Services at the VA Palo Alto Health Care System) and Joy Meier, Pharm.D., plus "How We Source Claims" — how every figure on the site is sourced and corrected when something doesn't hold up. Questions, corrections, or reform collaboration: outreach@brokenpromiseshealthcare.org.

Every Feature, One Page

Keep this page handy — it's the whole site in one table.

FEATURE	WHAT IT'S FOR	WHERE TO FIND IT
Product Lookup	Search a real product's NIH label, then check the clinical evidence behind it with an AI of your choice	/product-lookup
Top 25 Supplements	America's best-selling supplements, ranked by sales and rated against the evidence	/top-25-supplements
The Books	Three free volumes on evidence, regulation, and reform — read online, no purchase needed	#books
"What Are You Taking?"	Free printable medication & supplement worksheet, for your next appointment	In Book Two, The Hollow Aisle
Evidence Library	Every sourced citation on the site, searchable and organized by topic	/annotated-bibliography
FAQ	Quick, sourced answers to the most common supplement questions	/faq
Site-Wide Search	Search the books, guides, FAQ, and bibliography all at once	/search
What Should Change	The site's evidence-based policy recommendation for supplement reform	/appendix-what-should-change
About / Contact	Who wrote this, how claims are sourced, and how to reach them	#about · outreach@brokenpromiseshealthcare.org



Before You Take That Supplement, Check the Evidence.

Free for patients, clinicians, and the public — no sponsorships, no industry advertising, and no cost to use any part of this site.

[**supplements.brokenpromiseshealthcare.org**](https://supplements.brokenpromiseshealthcare.org)

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